

INDIAN EXPRESS UPSC IAS EDITION HD 22~07~2026
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Please Try To Read This Completely in 40 Minutes If You
Can't So Then You Have To Increase Your Efforts
All the topics of this UPSC IAS Edition are directly or
indirectly important for the prelims & main examination.
There are some topics which can be coded in answer writing of
other topics in the main exam.

● EAST ASIAN CRIME SYNDICATES ARE RUNNING BUSINESSES THAT USE MALWARE, GENERATIVE AI AND DEEPPAKES FOR SEXUAL EXTORTION AND EXPLOITATION

UN: International criminal groups using technology to expand in and beyond Asia

Associated Press
Bangkok, July 21

SOUTHEAST ASIA-BASED criminal groups are using increasingly integrated networks and technology to build a rapidly growing illicit economy with tentacles that reach far beyond Asia, with scams alone causing estimated combined losses of \$88.3 billion to \$114.1 billion in 2025, a UN report says.

The report by the United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime outlines how transnational crime that used to be concentrated in Southeast Asia has expanded to other regions, while global criminal groups are increasingly engaging in drug,

human and wildlife trafficking in Asia. Criminals are using new technologies to launder money through global financial systems and using artificial intelligence to steal from victims worldwide, said the report, released Tuesday. One key finding of the report is the threat to children both from AI and from online gaming, as hundreds of scam compounds scattered across Southeast Asia provide venues for sex trafficking and selling of child sexual abuse content.

“There is a huge jump in AI-generated child sexual images... communicated through encrypted communications platforms,” said Inshik Sim, UNODC researcher and coordinator for

the report, told reporters at a briefing at the Foreign Correspondents Club of Thailand.

East Asian crime syndicates are running businesses that use malware, generative AI and deepfakes for sexual extortion and exploitation in a trend that increases risks of in-person abuse as well as livestreamed abuse and grooming of victims. Apart from outright trafficking for the sex industry, victims can be sold into domestic servitude, forced begging and forced labor, among other forms of exploitation, the report says.

Social media and online gaming and gambling also pose dangers for children, the report notes, citing surveys showing



An estimated loss of \$88.3 billion to \$114.1 bn was reported in 2025. AP

that hundreds of children and teens across Southeast Asia are engaged in online gambling, some to the extent of addiction.

The report estimates the combined annual sales of illicit drugs in Southeast Asia and nearby countries at up to \$109

billion, with seizures of illegal shipments soaring. That includes methamphetamines, heroin and ketamine.

It points to the Sulu-Celebes maritime “triangle” between Indonesia, Malaysia and the Philippines as an increasingly important corridor for shipments of cocaine from Latin America to Asia, with illicit cargoes sometimes embedded in legitimate shipments such as Chinese tea.

The area is also often used for smuggling of wildlife and small arms, the report says.

Meanwhile, Thailand and Vietnam increasingly are the source of cannabis sent to Japan, where it is illegal, and to Europe, it says. Earlier this year, author-

ities in Malaysia’s Sabah seized more than 3 tons of methamphetamine, ketamine and ecstasy in the largest such seizure for Sabah so far. The report outlines how cross border financial and technology networks are supporting what it calls a “criminal service infrastructure” that facilitates global organized crime. The tools used include cryptocurrency, encrypted and private communications platforms and generative AI to create convincing phishing content, deploy real-time deepfake videos and voice calls. Using AI-powered translations, they can target victims across many languages at the same time, the report says.

Satellite communications also enable scam compounds to operate in places that are remote or subject to close surveillance.

To counter this growing criminal ecosystem, authorities need a coordinated, cross-border strategy that integrates enforcement across data, communications and financial systems, and online services and marketplaces, the report said.

As authorities in Thailand, China and elsewhere have raided industrial-sized scam centres mostly located in border regions of Myanmar, Laos and Cambodia, criminals have responded by shifting to other parts of the world or operating on a smaller scale.

AP

EXPRESS special

Census: 6 months to go, Govt explores how to count caste

Two options are self-declaration or drop-down menu of recognised castes; RSS among those with objections

Deeptiman Tiwary
New Delhi, July 21

E. EXPLAINED

Choices before Govt

WITH THE population enumeration phase of the nationwide Census just six months away, the Registrar General of India (RGI) is learnt to be grappling with the methodology for caste enumeration that is meant to be a part of it. Sources said two broad options are under consideration: allowing respondents to state their caste in an open-ended format or restricting entries to a drop-down menu of recognised castes.

While the first option risks a repeat of the 2011 Socio Economic and Caste Census (SECC) experience, when more than 46 lakh distinct caste names were listed by respondents, the second is learnt to have run into resistance from the RSS. The Sangh Parivar believes a drop-down menu based on existing caste lists would effectively reinforce the caste architecture institutionalised during British rule.

“It is a difficult exercise. There are multiple suggestions and objections, all of which are being considered. Various methods are being tested, including open-ended enumeration and ways to avoid a repeat of the 2011 outcome. Caste is a sensitive subject, and any error can have serious political ramifications,” a government source said.

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

• COIMBATORE AND MADURAI AT TOP IN FEMALE LABOUR FORCE PARTICIPATION RATE, MINISTRY DATA SHOWS

With a page out of China book, TN maintains lead in share of women workers

Siddharth Upasani
New Delhi, July 21

NEW DATA underlines how Tamil Nadu remains closest in India to replicating China's women-led electronics manufacturing model, with other states far behind.

The Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation's (MoSPI) recent report on the labour market in India's 46 most populous cities (with a population of more than 10 lakh as per Census

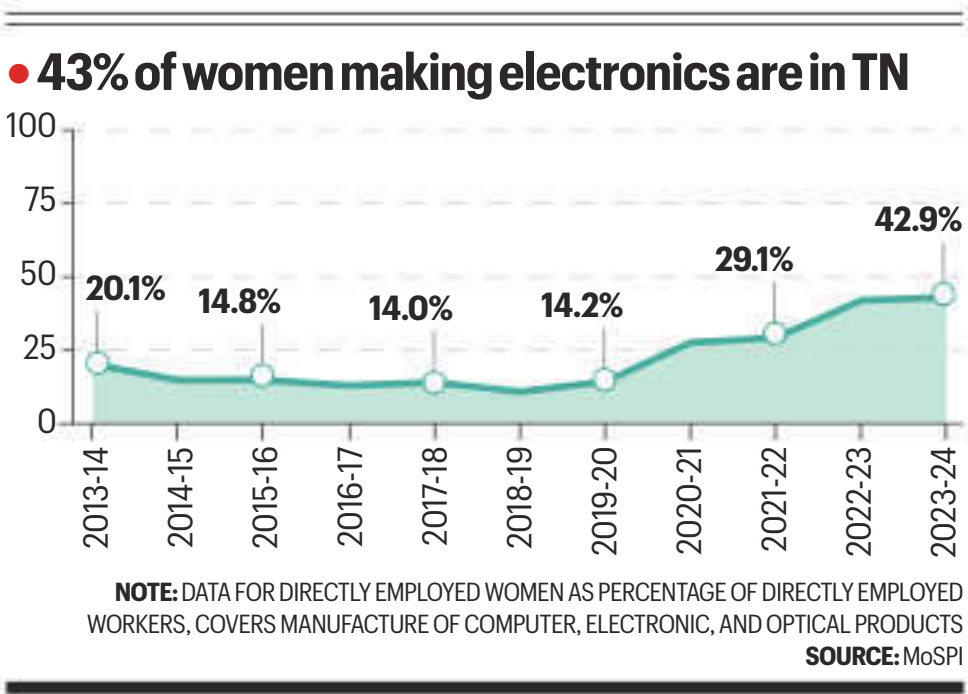
2011) shows that two Tamil Nadu cities — Coimbatore at 41.3% and Madurai at 37% — rank in the top three when it comes to the female Labour Force Participation Rate. This is well above the urban India average of 27.7%.

The Labour Force Participation Rate refers to the percentage of people either already employed or looking for work.

Sandwiched between the two, at 40.6%, is Surat. However, the Annual Survey of In-

dustries data shows that Gujarat's share among women employed in the manufacture of computers, electronics and optical products remained stagnant at 10% from 2013-14 to 2023-24, even as it grew from 20% to 43% for Tamil Nadu in the same period.

At the same time, Maharashtra and Karnataka saw notable declines in the share of women they employ in the manufacture of computers, electronics and optical products — 24% to 6%, and 11% to 8%, between 2013-14 and 2023-24.



As a percentage of all women directly employed in India's factories — irrespective of what they manufacture — Tamil Nadu remains the leader among states. It has largely held on to this lead, with its share showing only a slight decline from 43% in 2021-22 to 40% in 2023-24.

The TN effect

In 2023-24, Tamil Nadu accounted for nearly half the women directly employed (contract staff excluded) in the manufacture of computers,

electronics and optical products across the country — 14,814 of the total 34,531.

This figure has likely increased further since then after the inauguration in August 2024 by the state government and Foxconn of a women-only residential complex in Vallam Vadagal, Sriperumbudur. Built by the State Industries Promotion Corporation of Tamil Nadu (SIP-COT) at a cost of Rs 706.5 crore, it can house 18,720 workers.

The new MoSPI data on India's 46 biggest cities is also far from the complete Tamil Nadu

picture as it only covers cities which had a population of more than 10 lakh in Census 2011. This means new industrial hubs such as Hosur, Erode and Oragadam are not included as they had a population lower than that in Census 2011.

More recently, Tamil Nadu signed a Rs 15,000-crore agreement with Vikram Solar for the setting up of a Battery Energy Storage System manufacturing facility at the SIPCOT Industrial Park in Tirunelveli district, days after another MoU worth

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Jaishankar to meet Quad counterparts in Manila on sidelines of ASEAN meet

Shubhajit Roy
New Delhi, July 21

EXTERNAL AFFAIRS Minister S Jaishankar will visit Manila, Philippines, on July 22-23 to attend the Quad Foreign Ministers’ Meeting under the ASEAN framework, including the ASEAN-India, East Asia Summit (EAS), and ASEAN Regional Forum (ARF).

The MEA said that the visit “underscores India’s deepening engagement with ASEAN under the Act East Policy and reaffirms our strong commitment to further strengthening the ASEAN-India Comprehensive Strategic Partnership. It is of particular significance that 2026 has been designated as the ASEAN-India Year of Maritime Cooperation”.

It said that on the margins of the ASEAN-related meetings, “the External Affairs Minister will be participating in a Quad Foreign Ministers’ meeting with his counterparts from Australia, Japan and the United States. He is also expected to hold bilateral meetings with his counterparts from participating countries.”

In May this year, with an eye on China, the Quad Foreign Ministers decided to launch the Indo-Pacific Maritime Surveillance Corporation, expanding maritime domain awareness and enhancing port infrastructure in Fiji. They also agreed to launch the Indo-Pacific Energy Security initiative, which will focus on regional energy resilience. And they decided to proceed with concrete cooperation under the Quad Critical Minerals Initiative framework to strengthen supply chains.

The Foreign Ministers of India, the US, Australia and Japan will meet in Manila. But with the US and China engagement on one side and the strained ties between India and the US, there appears to be uncertainty over the Quad leaders’ summit this year in Delhi.

In May this year, when the Quad Foreign Ministers met in Delhi, the joint statement did



Russian Foreign Minister Sergey Lavrov (centre left) and Deputy PM of the Lao People’s Democratic Republic Thongsavanh Phommvihane (centre right) on the sidelines of the ASEAN Ministerial Meetings in Manila, on Tuesday. AP

E. EXPLAINED

Bridging the gap

The Quad grouping has faced challenges in the last year or so. With the US President Donald Trump reaching out to China and the strained ties between Delhi and Washington, there is a perceived gap between India and the US. But the Quad grouping meeting at the Foreign Ministers’ level signals some effort to bridge the gap.

not specify whether it would be held this year in Delhi or in some other country. The Quad Foreign Ministers’ meeting was originally planned to be held in Australia, but it was held in Delhi. So, officials said that it is

a “nimble” grouping, and the decision to hold the leaders’ summit will be taken by the Foreign ministers.

“We look forward to the convening of the Quad Leaders’ Summit, the next Quad Foreign Ministers’ Meeting, and continuing our engagements that advance peace, stability, and prosperity in the Indo-Pacific and beyond,” the joint statement had said.

The Philippines assumed the ASEAN Chairship for 2026 under the theme “Navigating Our Future, Together”, focusing on regional peace and security, economic integration, digital transformation, inclusive growth and people empowerment. It comes at a time when ASEAN seeks to strengthen resilience amid global uncertainties while advancing cooperation among member states and external partners, including India.

Sena (UBT) moves SC against MPs’ merger

Express News Service
New Delhi, July 21

THE SHIV Sena (UBT) on Tuesday moved the Supreme Court challenging Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla’s decision to recognise the merger of six of its MPs with the rival Shiv Sena led by Maharashtra Deputy Chief Minister Eknath Shinde.

Senior Advocate Devadatt Kamat, appearing for the petitioner, Shiv Sena (UBT) leader Arvind Ganpat Sawant, mentioned the matter before Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant, who was presiding over a three-judge bench, and sought an urgent hearing.

“Six of these MPs decide unilaterally, without the

merger of the original political party, and say we have merged with the rival. We contested against that political party,” Kamat submitted.

The senior counsel urged the bench to hear the matter soon, saying, “The urgency is that my functioning as a political party in Parliament has come to an absolute standstill. These MPs are not with me because the Speaker has recognised their merger with some other political party. This is intended for Parliament session.” The CJI said that he could not promise it would be listed this week.

On July 18, two days before the Monsoon Session in Parliament began, Birla recognised

the merger of six Shiv Sena (UBT) MPs—Sanjay Jadhav, Sanjay Patil, Sanjay Deshmukh, Omraje Nimbalkar, Nagesh Patil Ashtikar and Bhausaheb Wakchaure—with the Eknath Shinde-led Shiv Sena.

Sawant’s writ petition challenges “the ex-facie unconstitutional, illegal, and perverse circular dated 18.07.2026... issued by the Joint Secretary, Lok Sabha Secretariat...” recognising the merger. Sampat said these MPs were given tickets by the Shiv Sena (UBT) and contested the Lok Sabha elections on the name and symbol belonging to party (flaming torch or mashaal). “The entire organisation, rank and file, and the leadership of the political party

put immense effort and resources in campaigning for and securing their “victory... from their respective constituencies”, the petition said.

It further added “The Lok Sabha elections in 2024 were fought, inter alia, against the candidates sponsored by Shiv Sena led by Eknath Shinde. The campaign, inter alia, revolved around usurpation of the legacy of Balasaheb Thackeray by Eknath Shinde through illegal means and unconstitutionally orchestrated defections. The electorate of their constituencies, in electing... accepted and validated the campaign carried out by the SS (UBT) leadership and organisation,” the petition stated.

MP Assembly passes UCC Bill, Congress slams 'RSS agenda'

Anand Mohan J
Bhopal, July 21

THE MADHYA Pradesh Assembly on Tuesday passed the Madhya Pradesh Uniform Civil Code (UCC), 2026, Bill amid protests from the Opposition.

The legislation, introduced on the second day of the monsoon session on Monday, creates a common civil law governing marriage, divorce, inheritance and live-in relationships, while exempting Scheduled Tribes covered under Articles 342 and 366(25) of the Constitution. It bans polygamy, criminalises practices such as triple talaq and nikah halala, mandates registration of marriages, divorces and live-in relationships, and grants equal inheritance rights irrespective of gender.

Chief Minister Mohan Yadav, replying to the debate, described the legislation as a landmark reform. "Golden history is being written in this Assembly today," he said, adding that the law would "criminalise triple talaq and halala, prohibit polygamy, make registration of marriage and divorce mandatory and give equal inheritance rights to all children". Calling the legislation a fulfilment of the Constitution's vision under Article 44, Yadav said, "The fundamental



Congress leaders protest against the UCC Bill in Bhopal, Tuesday. PTI

spirit of the UCC is 'Equality for All, Respect for All'. It is not just our sentiment but the sentiment of the entire country. Everyone, especially women, should have their rights."

Launching a sharp attack on the Congress, he further alleged that the Opposition was opposing the legislation only for "Muslim appeasement". "If Congressmen have even a little respect for Babasaheb Ambedkar, they should wash away their sins by supporting the UCC," he said, adding, "Prime Minister Narendra Modi gave rights to Muslim women by abolishing

triple talaq. We are implementing the UCC so that Amar, Akbar, Anthony, Robin and Rahim all live under the same law."

He also defended the exclusion of Scheduled Tribes from the legislation. "The tribal community has been excluded in accordance with constitutional provisions. We have respected their constitutional safeguards and traditional rights." Explaining provisions of the law, he said, "Duties and rules are the same for everyone. The minimum age for marriage will be 21 years for men and 18 years for women. Marriage registration will be

mandatory. Only those who have married once will be allowed to live in Madhya Pradesh. Only after divorce will a person be able to live with a second life partner. No one will be able to arbitrarily say 'talaq, talaq, talaq'. Registration will also be required for live-in relationships."

He added that the UCC "is a great opportunity to provide equal opportunities and justice to people from all walks of life" and said, "This is a Bill that strengthens national unity, integrity, women's respect and social harmony."

Earlier in the debate, senior Congress MLA Arif Masood opposed the legislation and urged Speaker Narendra Singh Tomar to send it to a Select Committee. "This Bill contains many inconsistencies. The Union government itself has not implemented a Uniform Civil Code. The matter has remained pending before the Law Commission for three years." Masood argued that the legislation infringed constitutional protections. "The Bill violates the fundamental rights relating to culture and education guaranteed under Article 29 of the Constitution," he said, while moving amendments seeking detailed legislative scrutiny.

The House rejected the amendments by voice vote.

LoP Umang Singhar backed the demand to refer the legislation to a Select Committee, saying the state faced more pressing concerns. "There is no need for a Uniform Civil Code in Madhya Pradesh at present. The issue of 27 per cent reservation for OBCs is more important," he said.

Congress legislators later rushed to the Well of the House, shouting slogans, following which Speaker Narendra Singh Tomar passed the Bill by voice vote amid the din.

Outside the Assembly, Singhar accused the BJP government of using the legislation to pursue ideological objectives while ignoring governance issues. "The BJP government wants to implement the RSS agenda in the name of the UCC and is running away from the real issues of the people," Singhar said in a statement. "The government is asleep like a dead government when it comes to the people's problems. Farmers are facing a shortage of fertilisers, youth are wandering in search of employment, crimes against women are continuously increasing and scams are being exposed, but the government is silent on these serious issues."

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EXPRESS special

Given life, 44 Somali pirates hope to be sent home to serve out sentence

Sadaf Modak
Mumbai, July 21

THE 44 Somalis sentenced to life by a Special Court here Monday, for piracy and kidnapping among other charges, are hoping that they will be allowed to serve their terms back home.

Their convictions were the first under the Maritime Anti-Piracy Act, enacted in 2022. Ranging in ages between early 20s and 50s, the men have been jailed since April 2024. Barring one, none can speak English, and have had no visitors in the two years of their arrest.

During the sentencing Monday, the men raised their hands as accused No. 17 Li Banm Abdi Jama, the only one who can speak English among them, asked the court if they could return home to serve their punishment, as well as what the procedure would be now and when they could return.

Jama said the men had pleaded guilty in the hope that this would help their applications to serve out their time in Somalia. He talked about the severe hardships they were facing in jail due to differences in language, culture, diet and lifestyle, as well as the lack of any family and friends in the country.

Jama told *The Indian Express*: "We want to return. Even though we have no complaints in jail, it is difficult to adapt to living in a prison far from home. Communication is challenging, food prefer-



Ranging in ages between early 20s and 50s, the men have been jailed since April 2024. FILE

ences and culture are different. Currently, we are only in touch with our families through video-conferencing as per jail rules. At least in a jail in Somalia, they can visit us."

While the judgment did not lay down the next steps for the 44 men, who were brought to court with guards of the Navi Mumbai Police Commissionerate, Special Public Prosecutor Ranjeet Sangle told them in court that they could write to the Somali Embassy through the jail superintendent.

"As far as serving their life sentences are concerned, it is entirely the prerogative of the Government of India if it wishes to deport the convicts to Somalia under the bilateral Mutual Legal Assistance Treaty between the two nations," Sangle said.

Under the treaty, the Ministry of Home Affairs is the

nodal ministry and Central authority for seeking and providing mutual legal assistance in criminal law matters.

Special Judge S B Dige said the judgment will be sent to the government and the District Magistrate for further action.

As per a 2017 agreement between Somalia and India on the transfer of prisoners, nationals of the two countries can serve sentences back in their places. Similar bilateral agreements exist between India and other countries such as the UK, Italy, Russia.

Apart from charges under the Maritime Anti-Piracy Act, the men have been convicted under Sections of the IPC covering kidnapping for ransom, criminal conspiracy, attempt to murder, and carrying of weapons, after pleading guilty to the same too.

While 35 of them were ar-

rested on March 14, 2024, on charges of abducting the crew of merchant vessel Ex-Ruen, 14 days later, nine more were arrested for holding the crew of a fishing vessel hostage.

Deputy Superintendent of Police Maya More said their main challenge during the investigation was that the accused did not speak English.

"We had to go to the high seas for panchnamas. A Somali student from Pune University was contacted to act as interpreter... The men played different roles, from demanding ransom to holding the crew hostage, and had sophisticated weapons," More said, adding that it is up to the Centre to decide if the men should be sent to Somalia to serve their time.

Earlier cases

In 2017, 117 Somali men were sentenced to seven years in separate cases, following four anti-piracy operations by the Indian Navy and the Indian Coast Guard in 2011-2012. By then, they had spent almost an equal amount of time as under-trials, picking up Hindi and Marathi while in jail.

At their sentencing, the men requested the court for "maafi", saying they missed the food back home and their families whom they had not seen for years, and blamed the situation in Somalia for pushing them into piracy. However, the court told them to serve out their sentence. A year later, they returned to Mogadishu in flights chartered by the Somali government.

No stay on Kerala Waqf Board curbs, SC drops govt oversight clause

Express News Service
New Delhi, July 21

THE SUPREME Court on Tuesday declined to interfere with the Kerala High Court's ad-interim direction barring the state Waqf Board from taking any major decisions or incurring any capital expenditure as its constitution is prima facie not in conformity with the 2025 Waqf Amendment Act that requires the inclusion of two non-Muslim members and one Shia member in it.

A three-judge bench presided over by CJI Surya Kant, however, deleted the HC's direction that the Board function under the supervision of the government's joint secretary or additional secretary.

The bench, also comprising Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana, said, "In view of the opening line of para 6 (of the high court order), whereunder Board has been directed to not undertake any capital expenditure etc. without leave of the court, we are satisfied that there is no necessity for retention of last line of para 6 of the order. Consequently, the direction that the Board shall function under supervision of jt. secy/ additional secretary of government is hereby deleted."

The top court noted that the matter was coming up before the high court again on Wednesday and urged it to decide expeditiously. The court was hearing an appeal filed by the Board against the high court's interim direction, which came on public interest litigations (PILs) questioning its constitution.

‘Bulldozer justice’: Allahabad HC gives split verdict on safeguards

Amaal Sheikh
New Delhi, July 21

“SELECTIVE OUTRAGE results in selective injustice.” This observation by Justice Atul Sreedharan is at the heart of a split verdict delivered on Monday by the Allahabad High Court, concerning the Supreme Court’s 2024 ruling on so-called “bulldozer justice”, a term used for punitive demolition of properties linked to accused persons.

The verdict revisits one of the key questions raised by that ruling — once courts have said that demolitions cannot be used as a form of punishment, how far can they go in preventing governments from doing just that?

A Division Bench of Justice Atul Sreedharan and Justice Siddharth Nandan said that the state cannot demolish a house to punish the family for an alleged offence. However, the bench was split on whether the HC can go beyond the SC’s own directions and create additional safeguards against state action. The matter will now be referred to a third bench.

Delivering a scathing critique of what he described as the growing phenomenon of “bulldozer justice”, Justice Sreedharan said that demolition drives immediately following criminal accusations often appear designed not to enforce planning laws. Instead, they aimed “to satiate the perceived blood lust” of a society conditioned by television and social media to demand instant punishment.

He also noted that illegal colonies continue to emerge due to rampant corruption. Correcting planning violations, he said, cannot become “one sided action to correct the measures, by way of the retributive exercise of the executive discretion”.

He proposed safeguards beyond the Supreme Court’s own directions. Where demolition proceedings follow an FIR, a dwelling linked to the accused should ordinarily not be touched for two years, he held, since “the immediate action... is to satiate the presumable public anger immediately following the offence which would dissipate with the passage of time.”

After two years, authorities remain free to act in accordance with municipal law and the SC’s safeguards.

He also proposed that anyone who has lived in an allegedly unauthorised house for three years or more should ordinarily receive a year’s advance notice before demolition proceedings begin, dispensable only for “compelling urgency” of a larger public need. He said that the State is often “particeps criminis” or an accomplice in the original construction through corruption.

1996 Dausa blast: SC sets aside death sentence, says legal assistance denied

Court orders that Abdul Hameed be tried again, with proceedings to be concluded in a year; acquits the accused given life term

Ananthakrishnan G & Hamza Khan
New Delhi, July 21

THE SUPREME Court Tuesday set aside the conviction and death sentence of Abdul Hameed in the 1996 Samleti, Dausa, bus bomb blast case, citing denial of adequate legal assistance during his original trial. It also set aside the conviction of another key accused, Pappu alias Salim, while refusing to interfere with the High Court’s acquittal of the remaining persons in the case.

The May 22, 1996, blast killed 14 people and injured 37 as it ripped through a Rajasthan Roadways bus travelling from Agra to Bikaner near Samleti village in Rajasthan’s Dausa district. The blast came a day after the Lajpat Nagar bomb blast in Delhi in which 13 people were killed.

Overturning a July 2019 judgment of the Rajasthan High Court that had upheld Hameed’s conviction and capital sentence, a Supreme Court Bench comprising Justices Vikram Nath, Sanjay Karol and Sandeep Mehta ordered a fresh trial, directing that the proceedings be concluded within one year.

“The true measure of justice does not lie in the swiftness of retribution, but in the discipline of restraint. It is a canonical



(L-R) Mirza Nisar Hussain, Lateef Ahmad Waja, Raees Baeg, Mohammad Ali Bhatt and Abdul Goni were acquitted in July 2019 in the 1996 Samleti blast case. ARCHIVE

maxim of criminal jurisprudence that it is better for a hundred guilty persons to escape than for one innocent person to be condemned,” the Court observed.

“If the trial is found to have been conducted in breach of the constitutional guarantee of a fair trial, the very foundation of the conviction would stand vitiated,” the apex court said, adding that the proceedings of the trial court “do not reflect that Dr Abdul Hameed was represented by a legal counsel at any stage”.

Highlighting that 30 years have passed since the attack, the Supreme Court asked the High Court to assign the retrial to a specialised fast-track court presided over by a judicial officer with at least seven years of experience in sessions trials.

Clarifying that its order is based on the lack of fairness and procedural propriety in the case, and that it had not gone into its merits, the Court said: “The special court shall indepen-

dently appreciate the evidence... and decide the matter strictly on its own merits without being influenced by any observation contained in this judgement.”

The Court also spoke to Hameed, who is lodged in Jaipur Central Jail, via videoconferencing, during which he said that he had “not engaged any private counsel and that no legal aid counsel was ever provided to him by the trial court”.

One of the arguments by the prosecution in seeking death for Hameed was that he was also named in the Republic Day blast at SMS Stadium in Jaipur in 1996.

Incidentally, an outfit called the Jammu and Kashmir Islamic Front had taken responsibility for the Samleti blast at the time.

While Hameed, who was arrested on June 26, 1997, has now been in jail for 29 years, Salim was arrested a month later and was imprisoned for over 23 years before he was released on parole in 2020.

The trial court and the accused

Among the accused, Riaz Ahmad Sheikh, died during the pendency of the trial. Another accused, Kulwinderjit Singh, was discharged by Additional Sessions Judge, Bandikui, in February 2003. In 2014, the High Court dropped charges against a third accused, Chandra Prakash Agarwal.

Finally, 18 years after the blast, on September 29, 2014, the trial court convicted seven people – Hameed, Javed Khan, Abdul Goni, Lateef Ahmad Waja, Mohammad Ali Bhatt, Mirza Nisar Hussain and Raees Baeg, while acquitting Farukh Ahmed Khan on the grounds that the evidence against him could not be proved beyond reasonable doubt.

Of those convicted, Hameed was sentenced to death, and the others given sentences ranging from life to 10 years’ rigorous imprisonment.

The trial court concluded that Hameed and an associate had boarded the ill-fated bus, planted the bomb under the seats in front of them, and then disembarked.

Subsequently, in March 2017, the trial court held Salim also guilty and awarded him life imprisonment.

HC proceedings

The Rajasthan High Court remanded Hameed’s case to the trial court again for a fresh order of sentence, observing that he had been awarded death on the same day as he was convicted, and that at the hearing on the sentence, there was no counsel representing Hameed.

In December 2015, the trial court again awarded death to Hameed.

In July 2019, the High Court

upheld death for Hameed, while acquitting the six others convicted along with him. It also upheld the acquittal of Farukh. In a separate judgment, the court affirmed the sentence given by the trial court to Salim.

In September 2020, the High Court granted Salim permanent parole on his petition against the denial of parole to him.

Supreme Court

Hameed’s lawyer Kamini Jaiswal contended in the apex court that “the entire prosecution case is founded upon conjectures, surmises and legally inadmissible material and that the courts below gravely erred”.

“The case rests substantially upon circumstantial evidence and alleged confessional statements, and the prosecution has miserably failed to establish a complete and unbroken chain of circumstances leading only to the hypothesis of guilt of the said accused,” Jaiswal said, claiming “unreliable identification evidence, doubtful recoveries, unexplained contradictions, serious investigative deficiencies and a tainted and fundamentally flawed investigation”.

The lawyer also contended that the lower courts “erred in overlooking the serious infirmities surrounding the statement of Pappu (Salim) recorded as an approver”. The entire case against Salim rests “solely upon circumstantial evidence, there being no direct evidence whatsoever... Once the confessional statements are eschewed from consideration, there is no independent evidence”, Jaiswal further argued.

As for the other accused, the Court said that it finds “no justification to interfere” with their acquittal by the High Court.



People move to a safer place from a flood-affected area in Assam’s Sivasagar district on Tuesday. PTI

Water levels unseen in half a century, says CM as Assam flood toll rises to 11; 3L affected

Sukrita Baruah
Guwahati, July 21

LARGE PARTS of Assam continued to be flooded on Tuesday morning, with one more person dying in Upper Assam, taking the total death toll in this year’s floods in the state to 11.

According to Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma, the “unprecedented flooding” in the Upper Assam districts of Sivasagar, Jorhat and Charaideo has resulted in “water levels unseen in half a century”.

As of 8 am on Tuesday, five rivers — the Brahmaputra in Neamatighat, the Burhidihing in Khowang, the Dikhow in Sivasagar, the Disang in Nganglamuraghat, and the Dhansiri in Golaghat and Numaligarh — continued to flow over danger levels.

Large swathes of Upper Assam have been hit by floods caused by rivers swelling after

heavy rains since Sunday.

On Tuesday morning, 12,720 people were in a total of 52 relief camps set up in response to the acute flood situation, and a total of 9,160 people were evacuated by boats, officials said.

According to estimates by the Assam State Disaster Management Authority, a total of 3.1 lakh people were affected as of Tuesday morning, with 14,411 hectares of crop areas submerged.

“Landslides were reported in five parts of Guwahati on Monday evening. There have been no additional incidents on Tuesday,” an ASDMA official said.

Meanwhile, the Railways announced special trains to assist passengers stranded by train cancellations because of inundation of railway tracks in and around Simalguri town in Sivasagar district.



The Editorial Page

WEDNESDAY, JULY 22, 2026

Lifting off, reaching a new space milestone

THE SUCCESSFUL launch of Skyroot Aerospace's Vikram-1 rocket marks a defining moment in India's space journey. It signals a transition from a programme led almost exclusively by the state-run ISRO to one in which private enterprise is emerging as a driver of innovation. With this achievement, India entered an exclusive league: Until Skyroot's mission on Saturday, only private companies in the United States and China had independently developed and launched rockets that reached orbit. The milestone comes six years after the government opened the space sector to private participation in 2020, a reform that was then institutionalised through the Indian Space Policy, 2023. The results of the policy are beginning to show. The country is now home to around 400 space start-ups working across the value chain, from launch vehicles and satellites to space-grade electronics and downstream applications. The sector is currently valued at roughly Rs 70,000 crore, and the government expects it to expand four- to five-fold over the coming decade.

Skyroot's mission is also important because it's directed at the Low Earth Orbit (LEO) — a region of space where an increasing number of countries are looking to carve a niche. Today, Earth observation, weather forecasting and telecommunication are no longer the preserve of government agencies. While the large geostationary satellites that operate at altitudes close to 37,000 km are unlikely to be obsolete anytime soon, much of the space economy in the coming decades is expected to be driven by satellites that orbit between 160-2,000 km above Earth's surface. The proliferation of satellites weighing anywhere from a few kg to a few hundred kg has created a market that is expanding faster than any national space agency can serve on its own. Shifting commercial launches to private players would, therefore, free ISRO to focus on deep-space exploration missions such as Chandrayaan and Gaganyaan.

That said, ISRO's handholding role cannot be discounted. India's premier space research agency provided most of the infrastructure used to design Vikram-1. By all accounts, the contours of the public-private partnership in India will be very different from the US for at least a decade — companies such as SpaceX design and build products independently of NASA and then sell them to the space research agency. Indian companies like Skyroot could, instead, become competitive by working on the country's traditional strength in low-cost manufacturing. This is the way forward, but they will have their work cut out in an ecosystem whose unforgiving nature has been demonstrated by the collapse of US companies such as Vector Launch and Virgin Orbit.



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Online betting is spreading across Bangladesh like a silent disease.
— *The Daily Star, Bangladesh*

From 1991, three foreign policy lessons for managing disruption of certainties



RAJA MANDALA
BY C RAJA MOHAN

HISTORICAL ANALOGIES must be approached with caution. Yet there is a striking symmetry between the foreign policy challenges that confronted India in 1990-91 and those now posed by the wars in Iran and Ukraine. Simultaneous upheavals in the Middle East and Europe in 1991 shattered India's economic and strategic assumptions. Today, the two regions are again compelling Delhi to reconsider the foundations of its national strategy.

Iraq's invasion of Kuwait in August 1990, and the US-led war to reverse Saddam Hussein's annexation, sent oil prices soaring, disrupted remittances and aggravated India's balance-of-payments crisis. Within months, the Soviet Union — the principal anchor of Indian foreign policy during the Cold War — collapsed. The twin shocks forced India to reform its economy, diversify its international partnerships and rethink its place in the world.

The circumstances today are different, but the underlying challenge is familiar. The war that began with the killing of Iran's Supreme Leader on February 28 has raised energy costs, disrupted navigation through the Strait of Hormuz and exposed India's dependence on the Middle East.

The relief in Delhi after Washington and Tehran signed a memorandum of understanding in June has proved premature as the conflict escalates again. In Europe, meanwhile, the Ukraine war has entered its fifth year without a clear path to settlement. Russia is not about to disintegrate as the Soviet Union did in 1991. But the prolonged war, with its mounting costs, is generating new questions about Russia's future at home and abroad.

India is much better placed to manage these shocks than it was in 1991. It has a larger economy, greater diplomatic weight, and wider international partnerships. Yet its ex-



ILLUSTRATION: C R SASIKUMAR

posure to the world and the resulting vulnerabilities are greater.

American policies are intensifying this vulnerability. The sanctions legislation associated with the late Senator Lindsey Graham is proposing massive punitive tariffs against China, India and others importing Russian oil. President Donald Trump has also called for the legislation to be expanded to cover Iran. Whether or not Congress accepts that proposal, India's energy diplomacy will come under increasing stress.

The Indian government has shown considerable flexibility in navigating these pressures so far; but it could get trickier in the days ahead. As in 1991, however, the government appears more flexible than the foreign policy debate surrounding it might suggest. When Saddam invaded Kuwait, India's official position was caught between competing imperatives. It had to evacuate a large Indian expatriate population, preserve relations with Iraq and the Arab world, respond to the violation of Kuwaiti sovereignty, and accommodate the overwhelming military power assembled by the United States. The government's contradictory manoeuvres — including Foreign Minister I K Gujral's embrace of Saddam and

Iraq's invasion of Kuwait in August 1990, and the US-led war to reverse Saddam Hussein's annexation, sent oil prices soaring, disrupted remittances and aggravated India's balance-of-payments crisis

the provision of refuelling facilities to American military aircraft — reflected these multiple pressures.

But the domestic strategic consensus in 1991 was hardly realistic. Large sections of the political and foreign policy establishment sympathised instinctively with Saddam, long viewed as a friend of India and a representative of secular Arab nationalism. His annexation of an independent country was viewed as less important than his confrontation with the United States.

The same rigidity shaped Indian reactions to the Soviet crisis. By the late 1980s, Mikhail Gorbachev's internal reforms and retrenchment abroad had made clear that the old Soviet order was unsustainable. Yet a large section of Delhi's foreign policy community denounced him for seeking accommodation with the West. When communist hardliners attempted a coup in August 1991, there was barely concealed political glee in parts of Delhi. The coup collapsed within three days; the Soviet Union disappeared in December.

The protagonists have changed, but the instinct survives. Sympathy for Tehran often rests less on the character or conduct of the Islamic Republic than on its resistance to

America. Saddam's secular autocracy and Iran's Islamic theocracy are as different as chalk and cheese. Yet, the Indian foreign policy community embraced them both as symbols of anti-American defiance.

The debate on Russia is similarly personalised around Putin and sentimentalised through the memory of Soviet support for India. This obscures the need to examine Russia's internal strains, its changing relationship with China and its imperatives for reconciling with Europe and America. India's interests require an empathetic understanding of the domestic politics of Russia and Iran — not reflexive signalling of solidarity to the governments of the moment.

The first lesson from 1991, therefore, is that no balance of power is permanent. The certainties of the 1980s — a stable Soviet Union, a bipolar order and dependable partnerships — vanished with astonishing speed in 1991. Unpredictability is not an interruption of normal international politics; it is one of its permanent features. Indian strategy must devote as much attention to discontinuity as to continuity.

The second is that debate itself is a strategic asset. A foreign policy community organised around a rigid consensus will repeatedly miss inconvenient possibilities. India needs stronger expertise on Russia, Iran, Central Asia and the internal politics of the Middle East. India needs sustained investment, more than ever, in languages, history and regional specialisation. It also needs institutions willing to reflect on competing scenarios and encourage contrarian judgments.

The third and most important lesson is that external shocks and systemic changes cannot be managed by diplomacy alone. What rescued India after 1991 were the internal reforms. The answer must be the same today — sweeping domestic reform to cope with a changing world. Diplomacy's role then and now is to support internal transformation.

The writer is a contributing editor on international affairs for The Indian Express. He is also a Distinguished Professor at the Motwani-Jadeja Institute of American Studies, Jindal Global University and the Korea Foundation Chair on Asian Geopolitics at the Council for Strategic and Defense Research, Delhi

Delhi's winter pollution toolkit needs AI forecasts



MANMEET SINGH AND SANDEEP JUNEJA

DELHI'S DECISION to introduce a permanent winter pollution management framework marks an important shift in how the city responds to its annual air quality crisis. Measures such as staggered office timings, work-from-home arrangements, construction restrictions and tighter controls on vehicular emissions show that the government is moving from emergency response to advance planning. But one critical question remains: Even if emissions are reduced, when should people go outdoors?

Every winter, Delhi experiences strong temperature inversions that trap pollutants close to the ground, producing some of the world's highest concentrations of fine particulate matter, or PM2.5. Yet millions of schoolchildren, athletes, coaches, outdoor workers and event organisers continue to follow fixed morning schedules rather than atmospheric conditions. Daily Air Quality Index bulletins tell people when the air is "poor" or "severe," but rarely answer the more practical health question: What is the safest time today to be outside?

Our analysis of winter observations from November to January, using data from the Central Pollution Control Board, points to a clear pattern. We compared PM2.5 concentrations during the traditional morning window for school sports and outdoor activities, from 9 am to 12 pm, with those in the late afternoon, from 3 pm to 6 pm, when stronger atmospheric mixing typically helps disperse pollutants. The difference is striking.

At Anand Vihar, average PM2.5 concentrations fall from 275.3 ug/m³ in the morning to 170.4 ug/m³ in the late afternoon, a reduction of 38 per cent. In Rohini, concentrations decline by 40 per cent. RK Puram and Ashok Vihar record reductions of around one-third. Even Lodhi Road, among Delhi's cleaner monitoring locations, sees an average reduction of nearly 29 per cent. Pollution levels between 6 AM and 9 AM, when many training sessions and fitness activities begin, are similarly high to those between 9 AM and noon.

This pattern reflects a familiar feature of Delhi's winter atmosphere. Pollution remains trapped near the surface through the morning and often stays elevated into the early afternoon. The most consistent improvement occurs later in the day, between 3 pm and 6 pm. For children playing football, hockey, cricket or athletics, this timing matters. During vigorous exercise, breathing rates can rise by up to twenty-fold, allowing fine particulate matter to penetrate deeper into the lungs. A two-hour sporting event can therefore involve far greater pollution exposure than simply standing outdoors. Shifting activity to a cleaner time of day can substantially reduce exposure without requiring new infrastructure or additional regulation.

This is where AI can make Delhi's winter strategy more effective. Historical observations reveal broad patterns, but pollution varies from day to day depending on wind, temperature, cloud cover, regional biomass burning and local emissions. AI models can combine weather forecasts, satellite observations, ground-level monitoring and emissions data to predict how pollution will evolve hour by hour, and increasingly several days in advance.

That can turn air quality forecasting from a general information service into a practical decision-support tool. Instead of issuing only a generic warning that air quality will be "very poor," AI-enabled forecasts can answer operational questions: Should tomorrow's school sports meet begin at 9 AM or shift to 4 PM? Will pollution remain hazardous all day, requiring outdoor activity to be postponed? Which parts of the city are likely to see air quality improve earliest?

Delhi's new winter pollution framework rightly focuses on reducing emissions. AI forecasting would complement those efforts by helping governments, schools and communities reduce exposure while pollution-control measures take effect. With high-quality data, such forecasts could support decisions on school sports, marathons, outdoor work, public events and emergency health advisories. The evidence already supports one simple recommendation: Wherever possible, winter school sports and other outdoor physical activities should be scheduled in the late afternoon, between 3 pm and 6 pm.

India already uses predictive science to prepare for cyclones, floods and heatwaves. Air pollution should be treated no differently. Delhi has taken an important step by planning ahead to reduce emissions. The next step is to use AI-powered forecasts to help people decide when it is safest to step outside.

Singh is academic visitor and Juneja is director, Safexpress Centre for Data, Learning and Decision Sciences, Ashoka University, Delhi-NCR. Views are personal



ILLUSTRATION: TANUSHRI MITRA

IT BEGAN with a sound heard for the first time in the forests of Panna National Park. The crack of hydraulic breakers echoed, followed by the growl of excavators and the relentless crawl of bulldozers.

Hillsides were cut open, and forest tracks widened into construction roads. Concrete and steel arrived where only rock, river and trees stood before. One of India's largest engineering projects, the Rs 44,605-crore Ken-Betwa Link Project, had begun reshaping the landscape.

After decades of uncertainty, the project to link the Ken and Betwa rivers has entered a decisive phase, triggering a race to evacuate nearly 2,000 families across 10 villages — a rushed deadline that has fuelled protests across the submergence zone as residents challenge compensation surveys, eligibility lists and the terms on which they are being asked to leave.

For the administration, the remaining months are about meeting engineering timelines, completing rehabilitation and clearing the reservoir before the next phase of construction. For the many families still living in the shadow of the Daudhan dam — one of the main architectural features under the project — it's a struggle of a different kind: proving, through Aadhaar cards, school certificates, revenue records and decades-old family registers, that they belong to the places they are being asked to abandon.

When two rivers meet

The idea of linking India's rivers dates back to the early 1980s. The National Water Development Agency, set up in 1982 to examine the feasibility of interlinking river basins, identified the Ken-Betwa Link, as a priority project. The project, India's first inter-basin river link, aims to transfer water from the Ken to the Betwa basin.

A feasibility report followed in 1995, and in August 2005, Madhya Pradesh, Uttar Pradesh and the Centre agreed to prepare a Detailed Project Report. The Union Cabinet finally approved the project in December 2021, transforming the landscape around the rivers into construction sites.

Officials say that once ready, the project will irrigate 9.04 lakh hectares, utilise more than 4,843 million cubic metres of water, generate 103 MW of hydropower and 27 MW of solar energy, and supply nearly 194 million cubic metres of drinking water each year.

The irrigation network will extend across some of the most parched districts of Bundelkhand such as Chhatarpur, Tikamgarh, Panna, Damoh, Vidisha, Sagar, Shivpuri, Datia and Raisen in Madhya Pradesh, and Banda, Mahoba, Jhansi and Lalitpur in Uttar Pradesh.

At the heart of the project is the Daudhan dam planned across the Ken river in Madhya Pradesh — a structure that stretches for more than 2 km. The reservoir of the dam is designed to hold 2,853 million cubic metres of water, while two proposed power stations at the site are expected to generate more than 219 million units of electricity annually.

Water from the Daudhan reservoir will flow through a 221-km link canal (which gives the Ken-Betwa Link project its name) into the Betwa basin. The network also includes other irrigational structures such as the Lower Orr Project, the Kotha Barrage, the Bina Complex Multipurpose Project across Sagar and Raisen districts and the restored Ken Canal System in Uttar Pradesh.

Construction gathered pace in April 2025. By February 2026, officials said most of the machinery was in place, river diversion works were underway, and excavation of the Daudhan dam's foundation was in progress.

Beneath the appearance of steady progress is a parallel story — of environmental, administrative and engineering challenges.

Officials say additional private land is still needed to widen the approach roads to the dam. Acquisition proceedings covering nearly 28 hectares are underway, with notifications issued in some cases and records still being processed in others. Water pipelines, electricity lines and government structures within the project's right of way also remain incomplete, said a project engineer.

But the biggest set of unresolved tasks concerns rehabilitation. Villages within the submergence zone must be evacuated before construction can proceed in full.

Official project documents estimate that construction of the Daudhan dam will directly submerge about 2,171 hectares of village land, while the wider submergence area spans roughly 9,000 hectares.

The project's resettlement and rehabilitation plan identifies 1,913 affected families across 10 villages, with an estimated population of 8,339. The region has a significant tribal presence. Scheduled Tribes account for 33.9% of residents.

But the biggest headache for the state government is the Environmental Clearance stipulation by the Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change which mandates that all "rehabilitation and resettlement issues be completed before commissioning of the project".

Those left behind

The paperwork suggests rehabilitation is nearing completion, but Daudhan village — a 20-minute ride from the dam site through unmotorable roads cutting through the forest — suggests otherwise.

Houses stand ripped open, roofs pulled down, walls sliced in half by excavators. Entire lanes end in mounds of rubble, twisted steel and broken timber. On May 13, 2026, the administration brought in bulldozers. While officials say they only pulled down homes of those who had relocated, as well as vacant structures on government land, villagers allege the demolition was carried out without adequate warning.

For two weeks, a few hundred villagers from Daudhan, Palkhua and Sukwaha, the three villages in the submergence zone of the dam, sat on a protest by the banks of the



INDIA'S FIRST INTER-BASIN RIVER LINK

KEN, BETWA AND A LINE DRAWN ON WATER

After decades of uncertainty, the Ken-Betwa river linking project, which aims to irrigate the parched Bundelkhand region, is now racing to meet new deadlines. ANAND MOHAN J travels along the Ken to see how a Rs 44,605-crore engineering project is reshaping the river — and the lives along its banks



For two weeks, villagers from Daudhan, Palkhua and Sukwaha sat on a protest by the banks of the Ken, in Kupi village; in Daudhan, houses stand ripped open, roofs pulled down; at the resettlement colony in Kavar Karondiya, in Chhatarpur district. PHOTOGRAPHS BY ANAND MOHAN J

• The project in numbers

9,000 ha

of land likely to be submerged

5,258 ha

of this is forest land

4,141 ha

is core Panna Tiger Reserve land

9.04 lakh ha

of land is expected to get water for irrigation from the project

194

million cubic metres of drinking water is expected to be supplied every year, once the river linking project is ready

Ken, in Kupi village, alleging irregularities in land acquisition, rehabilitation and compensation for families affected by the project. On July 19, police detained their leader, social activist Amit Bhatnagar and several other demonstrators from the site, effectively ending the protest for now.

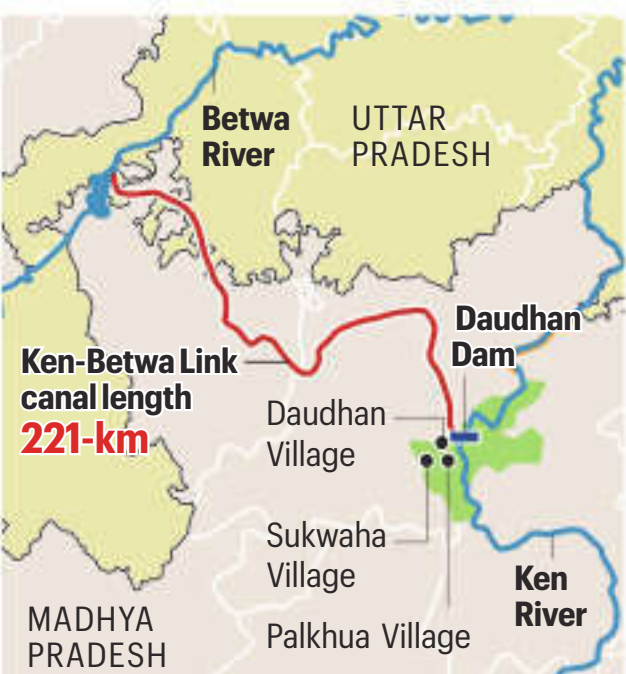
In September 2023, the Madhya Pradesh government had announced a special rehabilitation package for families affected by the Daudhan dam, under which every adult in a family is entitled to Rs 12.5 lakh, with a couple counted as a single unit. Compensation for homes range from Rs 50,000 to Rs 1.5 lakh. In addition to this, they are given plots in Kavar Karondiya, a notified resettlement colony 25-30 km by road from Daudhan, where they can build new homes.

Yet, amid the rubble in Daudhan, dozens of families remain, many insisting they were left out of surveys, denied compensation or never recognised as separate households.

Nandkishore Adivasi spends most afternoons squatting on the floor of his mud house in Daudhan, grinding red chillies into chutney on a stone slab. The house has stood here for generations. His family has already moved to the resettlement colony in Karondiya, but he stayed behind because the house was never counted during the survey and his mother was not counted. "I want to leave; my house does not have electricity, water or even a proper toilet. But not until my mother receives her compensation," he says.

A few lanes away, Phool Chand was counted, but his daughter was not. "My house has also not been counted. The local *patwari* (land record official) made a mess of the survey. My elder daughter was not counted. The school in the village has been shut for months now, and my younger daughter is at home," he says.

Mannu Yadav, widowed decades ago when her husband drowned in the Ken,



clutches her Aadhaar card as she speaks. In the absence of any other document, it is the only one with which she can argue that she exists in a place where, according to the survey records, she does not. "The government does not recognise me, they didn't count me. I am fighting to change that," she says.

Across Daudhan, where an estimated 100-150 people still remain, the same administrative gaps recur with minor variations: a house omitted from the survey, a missing name, an excluded family member, an undercounted parcel of land.

Chhatarpur Collector Parth Jaiswal says the district has already shifted about 380 families from Daudhan in the first phase and subsequently extended rehabilitation benefits to another 100 families. "We have disbursed around Rs 750 crore in compensation. If there are people left behind, I will ensure as many surveys as possible," he said.

Official reports show the rehabilitation exercise has advanced well: in Chhatarpur, nearly 89% of land compensation, almost 96% of asset compensation and more than 96% of rehabilitation payments have been

disbursed. Across neighbouring Panna, close to 90% of land compensation and almost all rehabilitation payments have been released.

"Once the river diversion begins, the remaining houses cannot stay in the submergence area. We have to complete the evacuation before that stage," says Jaiswal.

Jaiswal said only about 30 to 35 cases remain unresolved in Daudhan village, but they are also the most complicated. "These are not simple cases... Most involve disputes over eligibility or documentation."

The struggle to get counted

What a family loses by leaving Daudhan extends far beyond what any compensation schedule can capture. Those living in the forests around Panna collect seasonal produce, and walk familiar paths with landmarks that existed only because generations before them had learnt where water lingered, where wildlife moved and where crops could survive another uncertain monsoon.

A good mahua season could pay for a wedding, school fees or an old debt. The tendu harvest brought weeks of work, while amla, honey and fuelwood sustained families through the year. Even those who migrated to construction sites in Delhi or Gurgaon often returned for the mahua bloom and the tendu harvest.

What the *patwari*'s compensation register does record — land, houses, standing crops and recognised family units — has, in the final months before these villages disappear, acquired extraordinary importance. For generations, land anchored a family's identity and inheritance. Today, that role increasingly belongs to the plastic folder carrying Aadhaar cards, school certificates, voter identity cards, revenue records and handwritten family registers, shuttled from one government office to another in the hope of proving who the state recognises.

• Key projects

DAUDHAN DAM

77-METRE-HIGH

• 2,853 million cubic metres gross storage capacity

• 70% foundation excavation is done

• 13% excavation completed for dam approach channel

• Work on river diversion, foundation concreting, construction of the main dam body, spillway, gates yet to begin

LINK CANAL

EARLY STAGES

• 65% of work on access roads completed

• Designs of 2 tunnels are yet to be finalised

• 21% of tunnel portals is built

HYDROPOWER STATIONS

130 MW TOTAL CAPACITY

• Power House-I location is under verification

• DPR for Power House-II yet to be finalised

Collector Jaiswal rejects allegations that the rehabilitation survey was flawed. "Every house was photographed, every family documented. People were informed repeatedly through *gram sabhas*," he says.

Sukwaha sits deep inside the forest, reached by an uneven track that is still not fully motorable, making this a 70-km commute from Daudhan dam.

The village is small, with its mud houses — many of them now partially razed, like in Daudhan and Palkhua — scattered between patches of cultivation and trees.

Krishna Adivasi struggles to describe his loss in monetary terms because much of what sustained his family was never recognised as an asset in the first place. "They took our forest, our river and our mahua," he says.

His family of eight received a mere Rs 12 lakh; he says he won't move out until he gets what he is entitled to. Today, several of his family members travel to Chhatarpur for daily-wage work. "Everything has changed. My children dropped out of school," he says.

Vidya Rani once owned three houses and farmland in Sukwaha. Only her husband received Rs 12 lakh in compensation. "If we want to buy new fertile land, the rates are up to Rs 10-20 lakh. We can never buy back what we lost," she says. Her school-age children work as farm labourers in villages. "We don't want more money. We just want enough land to survive."

Santosh Adivasi has become an unlikely broker in Palkhua village, 10 km from the dam site. A property dealer, he sits with a cloth bag full of cash, counting bundles of notes into the hands of villagers as they sell whatever private land lies outside the project's acquisition boundary. For many, these sales are the only way to bridge the gap between the compensation received and the cost of starting over elsewhere. Most plots, he says, fetch between Rs 2 lakh and Rs 5 lakh.

Kalu Adivasi spent years working on construction sites in Delhi before returning to Palkhua when the work dried up. He had bought a parcel of land to set up a store near his village for Rs 3 lakh. He was forced to sell it for Rs 2.5 lakh. "The administration warned us to find new land, otherwise my shop will be demolished after the monsoons. So we have to sell our precious land...it's heartbreaking," he said.

A new beginning

At the resettlement colony in Kavar Karondiya, in Chhatarpur district, fresh brick houses stand beside half-finished ones. Courtyards are filled not with cattle or kitchens, but stacks of bricks, steel rods and cement bags waiting for the next stage of construction. There is no water supply and the resettled villagers shell out Rs 500 for 5,000-litre water tankers.

Ram Swarup says he has spent nearly half his compensation money on building two modest houses. His 17-year-old son has dropped out of school to work as a labourer. Around him, neighbours constantly weigh the price of bricks, cement, iron and sand against the compensation they received.

Dasharath Adivasi from Daudhan, who now runs a small shop selling chips, chewing gum and ice lollies in Karondiya, says he earns Rs 300-400 a day. Back in the village, there were days when he made Rs 5,000 a day. "Half the village hasn't shifted here yet. Without people, there is no business," he says.

Durji Adivasi walks nearly a kilometre every morning to the colony's only hand pump. Filling two buckets can take up to 40 minutes before she carries them home. The family cannot afford tanker water, she says, and the nearest ration shop is about six kilometres away. But she is gradually discovering a new life. "In Daudhan, our house didn't even have electricity," she says, sitting under a lone, white bulb. "Also, I now have a radio. I have been listening to songs".

• SCIENCE

IISc’s novel method holds promise for oral cancer treatment

Arnav Chandrasekhar
Bengaluru, July 21

IN A recent scientific breakthrough, researchers from the Indian Institute of Science (IISc) in Bengaluru, in collaboration with the M S Ramaiah Medical College, have discovered potential applications of an ultrasound stimulation technology in treating oral cancer.

Given the prevalence of chewable tobacco products, oral cancer is a significant health concern in India, accounting for about 1 in 4 of all global cases. The study, titled “Revealing biomechanical vulnerabilities in oral cancer cells using 3D coculture platform and low-frequency ultrasound”, was published in the journal *Materials Today Bio*.

What were the findings?

The study used samples taken from 15 patients with Stage 4 oral cancer. It found that oral cancer cells were selectively vulnerable to Low Frequency Ultrasound (LFU) mechanostimulation, a non-invasive procedure.

The team used a “3D co-culture platform” that essentially mimicked the environment of a tumour. Cancer cells form a barrier-like structure around the centre of a solid tumour, which normally blocks infiltration by drugs and immune cells. The treatment focused on breaking down these cells.

According to assistant professor Ajay Tijore, corresponding author of the study, high-frequency ultrasound is widely used in medicine (mostly for diagnostic and imaging purposes), but it has relatively low penetration depth in the body — only upto a few centimetres. Another type is High Intensity Focused Ultrasound (HIFU), which generates heat to “burn” cells in cases such as prostate cancer, which has certain side effects.

USE OF ULTRASOUND

● According to professor Ajay Tijore, high-frequency ultrasound is widely used in medicine (mostly for diagnostic and imaging purposes).

● But it has relatively low penetration depth in the body. Another form is High Intensity Focused Ultrasound, which generates heat to “burn” cells in cases such as prostate cancer, with certain side effects.

On the other hand, Low Frequency Ultrasound mechanostimulation is quite novel in terms of application in the field of oral cancer. The first author of the study, PhD student Rashmita Luha, said, “What surprised us most was the consistency of the response across cancer cells derived from multiple patients from different cancer stages. They were highly vulnerable to ultrasound, while normal cells were much less affected.”

The reason for this selective effect on cancer cells without affecting normal ones was the presence of a protein called Tropomyosin 2.1, which is present in normal cells but found at a lower level in cancer cells. Professor Tijore said, “Due to the loss of these proteins... when you apply such LFU mechanical stimulation from the outside, cancer cells cannot withstand these forces.”

What applications could it have?

A 2024 study in the journal *Oral Oncology* stated that Indians have a five-year survival rate of 50% after treatment, compared with 68% in developed nations. The rate refers to the likelihood of survival after detection, seen in relation to the population without cancer.

According to Tamil Nadu-based oral and maxillofacial surgeon Dr Senthil Kumar, people seeking oral cancer treatment in India currently face several challenges, such as high costs.

“Another issue is identifying the case at earlier stages, and for patients to seek early treatment. Educating patients and inculcating awareness is also important... if there is a benign lesion in the mouth, it has to be followed and evaluated every 3 to 6 months,” he said. Generally, treatment includes a combination of surgery and radiation, and chemotherapy.

Before its use, the new IISc ultrasound technology must also consider potential problems, Dr Kumar said. “On application of pressure, the spillage of cancer cells into neighbouring tissues is the biggest concern. Most surgical-onco treatments like neck dissection (to remove lymph nodes from the neck) are designed based on this consideration.”

The new LFU method could be used across different cancer treatments, such as breast cancer and melanoma (a type of skin cancer). Professor Tijore said, “This is because these are the relatively superficial cancers which could be monitored easily compared to tumours located deep inside the body.” IISc has also patented the ultrasound technology.

• ECONOMY

Education’s falling share in Budget over 12 years



UDIT MISRA

OVER THE past three days, New Delhi’s Jan-tar Mantar has attracted significant attention as many disgruntled youth from across India have come together under the leadership of the so-called Cockroach Janta Party to demand the resignation of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan.

The immediate trigger for the protests was the leak of the 2026 NEET-UG question paper. Every year, millions of students hoping to become doctors take the exam. This was neither the first time NEET papers got leaked, nor was it the only examination to witness such a lapse. Reports suggest that over the past decade, test papers have been leaked in over 150 different competitive examinations held in India.

What has intensified criticism is the sense of lack of accountability around such repeated lapses. A recent investigation by *The Indian Express* into the status of cases linked to 45 major exam paper leaks over the past two decades, where each exam saw at least one lakh applicants, threw up stark results.

Only two of these cases led to convictions. Most are either trapped in legal quicksand or have hit a dead end. In fact, two of the accused in exam leaks are now representatives in the Uttar Pradesh Assembly.

At a time when the Narendra Modi-led government’s handling of the education sector is under scrutiny, how can its performance be analysed? There is no singular metric, but the allocation of money from annual Budgets to the relevant departments and ministries is a good way to understand the importance any government attaches to a particular issue.

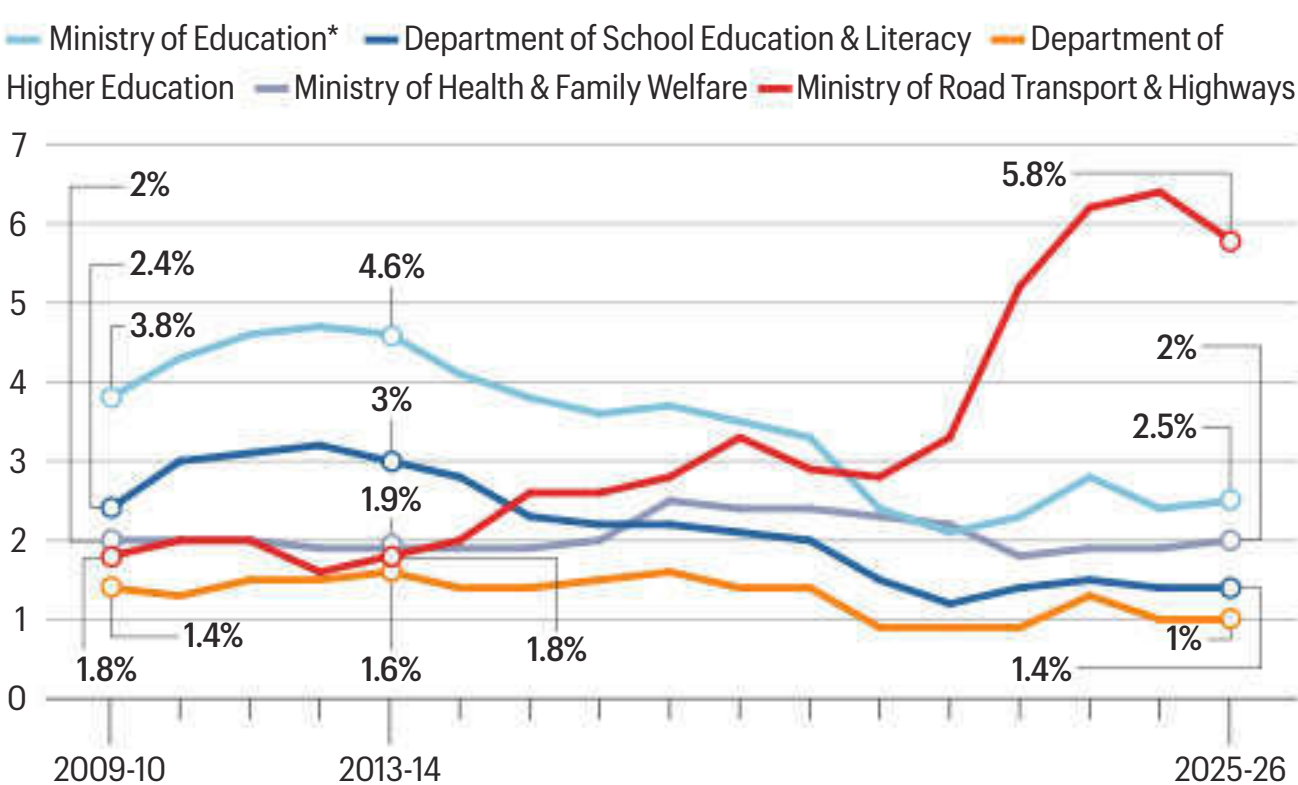
In the past, several scholars have repeatedly criticised Indian governments for not allocating enough funds to critical ministries such as education and health. Here is a look at how the annual allocations towards the Education Ministry in the Union Budgets have changed over the years.

Examining Budget allocations

It is natural that over time, the absolute amount allocated to any major ministry

• WHERE THE GOVERNMENT CHOSE TO SPEND

The chart & table show allocation to various ministries and departments as a % of total Union Budget



*EARLIER CALLED MINISTRY OF HUMAN RESOURCE DEVELOPMENT; SOURCE: CMIE, INDIAN EXPRESS RESEARCH

will increase, if for no other reason than the annual inflation in prices of the same goods and services. The metric for ascertaining whether a ministry or department lost or gained relevance in policy terms is to look at the funds allocated to it as a percentage of the total Budget for a financial year.

Since Budget Estimates have routinely changed, the following exercise only looks back on the period for which hard data is available. In other words, all analysis uses data up to the end of the last financial year. The starting point for the data is 2009, the earliest year for which the Centre for Monitoring Indian Economy’s (CMIE) Economic Outlook module provides details.

When the data is compiled, a clear picture emerges of the Education Ministry’s relative importance, or the lack of it, during the first 12 years of this NDA government.

Reducing share since 2014

Looking back at the Union Budget from 2009-10 onwards, it becomes clear that, on average, the total size of the Union Budget grew by an average of 10.4% each year. This means that the total amount of money the government spent each year was roughly 10% more than what it spent the year before. As such, across most ministries and departments, Budget allocations (in abso-

Sharp contrast

The Education Ministry’s share in the Budget fell from 4.6% in 2013-14 (the last year the UPA was in power) to 2.5% in 2025-26.

The share of money spent on making roads and highways has almost trebled to 5.8% in the past 12 years.

lute terms) also went up.

In this analysis, however, the focus is not on the absolute amount of money spent on a ministry but whether its share in the overall Budget expanded or shrunk or remained stagnant. The chart maps the relative share (in the overall Budget) of three key ministries over the years:

- Education (earlier called Ministry of Human Resource Development). The chart also maps the share of allocations for the two departments under this ministry: School Education and Higher Education.
- Health and Family Welfare
- Road Transport and Highways

The data on the other two ministries provide context by showing other sectors where people often demand higher allocation (health) and which represent the growth model of the Modi era (roads and highways).

The data shows that the Education Ministry’s share in the Union Budget fell from 4.6% in 2013-14 (the last year that the Congress-led UPA government was in power) to 2.5% in 2025-26. In other words, the Education Ministry now commands only half the share that it had before PM Modi took charge. The fall in relative share can also be seen in the allocation to both departments. The share of the Department of School Education is less than half of what it was 12

• GEOPOLITICS

First sanctions, now war: India’s Chabahar plans up in the air

Divya A
New Delhi, July 21

A DRAMATIC image posted on social media by US Secretary of War Pete Hegseth last week fuelled concern in India. It showed the maritime control tower at Iran’s Chabahar port collapsing after US strikes.

While New Delhi is already reeling under the impact of US sanctions on its strategically vital infrastructure project in Iran, where it has invested billions, the military strikes sparked fresh concerns.

The Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) clarified that the terminal it operates at Chabahar Port was not damaged in the US strikes. The ministry, however, reiterated India’s position that civilian infrastructure should not be targeted during conflicts.

India’s stakes in Chabahar

The Chabahar port has two main terminals — Shahid Beheshti and Shahid Kalantari — with India managing the former. It is operated by India Ports Global Ltd under a 10-year renewable agreement with Iran’s Ports and Maritime Organisation.

India and Iran have been developing Chabahar as a key trade and connectivity hub, particularly to improve access to

Afghanistan and Central Asia. Chabahar holds strategic importance for India as it provides an alternative trade route to Afghanistan, bypassing Pakistan, which does not allow Indian goods transit through its territory. For Iran, Chabahar is vital because it is its only oceanic port with direct access to the Indian Ocean, bypassing the congested Strait of Hormuz.

To ensure its continuous operation, India and Iran signed the landmark 10-year contract in May 2024 — replacing previous short-term contracts — to equip and operate the Shahid Beheshti terminal. To avoid financial penalties in the wake of US sanctions, India prepaid its \$120 million investment and transferred its operational stake at Shahid Beheshti to local entities.

US sanctions

US sanctions on Chabahar stem from its broader economic and military measures against Tehran. Despite India’s efforts to develop the port for regional connectivity, the history of these sanctions and waivers has severely restricted the project’s progress.

In 2018, the Donald Trump administration walked the US out of the Iran nuclear deal, and imposed sanctions on dealing with Tehran. At the same time, it granted a

More than maritime infra

● The sea-land transit route from Chabahar, that allows India to bypass Pakistan, is viewed as an important part of the International North-South Transport Corridor (INSTC).

● INSTC is a multi-mode transport network connecting India with Iran, Russia, Europe and parts of Central Asia. In that sense, the port represents far more than maritime infrastructure.

● The end of the US’s Chabahar waivers tilts the regional balance toward China and Pakistan.



targeted sanctions waiver for the Chabahar port to support humanitarian and economic efforts in Afghanistan.

For several years, the port facilitated the delivery of Indian wheat and medical supplies to Afghanistan. In September last year, the US administration withdrew the sanctions waiver, only to grant the exemption again through a six-month waiver in October that officially expired on April 26. Owing to the end of the sanctions

years ago, while the Department of Higher Education’s share is just around 60% of what it used to be.

The share of allocation to the Health Ministry has gone up and down marginally from one year to another, but the share is stagnant over the long term.

In sharp contrast, the share of money spent on making roads and highways has almost trebled in the past 12 years. In fact, 12 years ago, education and health together received 6.5% of the annual Budget while the ministry received just 1.8% of the total expenditure. All these years on, education and health together received only about 4.5% of the annual Budget while the Ministry of Road Transport and Highways receives 5.8% alone.

Skill development allocations

Over the years, especially with the rise of artificial intelligence, governments have focused on skilling over and above education. In fact, in 2015-16, the Union government created a new ministry just for this purpose. However, the share of the Budget spent on skilling presents a sobering picture, and is quite in contrast to the government’s pronouncements to “Skill India”.

As the table shows, the share of allocations to the Ministry of Skill Development was a minuscule 0.06% to begin with, and has now slid to 0.05%.

The takeaway

Looking at the share, level and trend of allocations provides a good understanding of a government’s priorities. To be sure, each government is entitled to choose its own set of priorities — after all, this is exactly why voters choose or discard governments. The Modi government is now in its third consecutive term, suggesting that voters have resoundingly ratified the government’s policy choices.

Yet, the decline in the share of allocation to the Ministry of Education is worrying for the future of India’s youth and their growing aspirations. And while spending more money is no guarantee for the quality of expenditure — as many cases of sinking new roads and falling bridges attest — it is often a necessary first step towards improving the situation. The picture emerging from this data echoes the words of the noted economist John Kenneth Galbraith: “I am worried about our tendency to over invest in things and under invest in people.”

waivers, India is losing its direct operational control over the Chabahar project.

The MEA has said India has been in discussions with “relevant stakeholders” after the expiry of the waiver.

Importance for Delhi, Tehran

Chabahar is vital for India not only because it provides direct, secure access to Afghanistan and Central Asia, but also because it serves as a counterweight to China’s development of the Gwadar Port in Pakistan, located just 140 km away.

For Tehran, it also serves as a crucial economic hub in the Sistan-Baluchistan province, functioning as a gateway to connect Iran with landlocked Central Asian states, Afghanistan and Russia.

Future hangs in balance

Chabahar had received an allocation of Rs 400 crore in the previous financial year. But the Union Budget for 2026-27 made no allocation for the port.

The current situation has left questions hanging over the future of this strategic route. Without Chabahar, India loses its primary non-Pakistani corridor to landlocked markets, effectively undoing New Delhi’s decades of connectivity planning.

• LEGAL

How a new law aims to place ‘Vande Mataram’ on a par with ‘Jana Gana Mana’

Vineet Bhalla
New Delhi, July 21

UNION HOME Minister Amit Shah is set to introduce the Prevention of Insults to National Honour (Amendment) Bill, 2026, in Rajya Sabha during the Monsoon Session. This will amend the Prevention of Insults to National Honour Act, 1971, to grant the national song, *Vande Mataram*, the same statutory protection currently given to the national anthem, *Jana Gana Mana*.

According to Section 3 of the Act, intentionally preventing the singing of the national anthem or causing a disturbance to any assembly engaged in such singing is a criminal offence punishable with imprisonment of up to three years, a fine or both. The Bill proposes to include the national song within the ambit of this section.

Legal status of national song

This year, the Ministry of Home Affairs issued guidelines regarding the singing and playing of the national song. The “orders

relating to the National Song of India” detailed the authorised lyrics, written by Bankim Chandra Chatterjee, and specified occasions for its mass singing, such as “on the unfurling of the National Flag, on cultural occasions or ceremonial functions”.

The orders also stated that “whenever the official version of the National Song is sung or played, the audience shall stand to attention”, and suggested that “in all schools, the day’s work may begin with community singing of the National Song”.

A petition, filed in the Supreme Court by one Muhammed Sayeed Noori, challenged the directives. Arguing for him, Senior Advocate Sanjay Hegde questioned whether people could be “compelled to sing the song in the garb of an advisory”.

A three-judge bench headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant, however, dismissed the plea as “premature” and based on a “vague apprehension of discrimination”. The court said that the government’s directive was advisory in nature and there were no penal consequences for those who

chose not to sing the national song.

How it differs from the national anthem

The Statement of Objects and Reasons of the Bill states that on January 24, 1950, Constituent Assembly President Rajendra Prasad declared that ‘Vande Mataram’ should be “honoured equally” and have “equal status” with ‘Jana Gana Mana’. It then states that “presently, there is no specific legal provision to prevent insults” to the national song.

The national anthem and the national song, however, don’t have equal status within the legal framework. Under Article 51A(a) of the Constitution, it is a fundamental duty of every citizen to respect the national flag and the national anthem. The national song is not mentioned here or anywhere else in the Constitution.

This distinction is also reflected in the government’s executive orders containing guidelines on both. While the playing of both is recommended for the arrival of the

President, a Governor or a Lieutenant Governor at state functions, immediately before and after the President addresses the nation over All India Radio and “(w)hen the National Flag is brought on parade”, the anthem is additionally mandated for “Civil and Military investitures”, during parades, for “hoisting of colours in the Navy” and “when the Regimental Colours are presented”.

The orders for the national song exclude such military protocols, specifying its playing only for “civil investitures”.

Disrupting anthem’s singing

To understand how the amended law might operate, one might look at how courts have interpreted the existing Section 3 of the 1971 Act, which currently applies only to the national anthem.

In 2014, the Kerala High Court in *Salman v. State of Kerala* clarified what constitutes such a disturbance. The court refused to quash an FIR against the petitioner, accused of “making noise and hue and cry” while the national anthem was being sung,

Justice P Ubaid held that “causing obstruction or prevention to the singing of National Anthem, by making loud or contemptuous noise” falls under the offence defined in Section 3 of the Act and ruled that such serious allegations require police investigation.

Right to respectful silence

While actively disrupting the singing of the national anthem is an offence under the Act, the Supreme Court distinguished this from simply choosing not to sing in the landmark *Bijoe Emmanuel & Ors v. State of Kerala* judgment of 1986.

The case involved three children belonging to the Jehovah’s Witnesses Christian sect who were expelled from school for refusing to sing the national anthem during a morning assembly, even though they stood respectfully in silence while it was sung. Their refusal was based in their religious faith that did not permit them to sing praises to anyone except in prayers to their God.

The Supreme Court ruled in favour of

the students, holding that their expulsion violated their fundamental rights to freedom of speech and expression under Article 19(1)(a) and freedom of religion under Article 25(1) of the Constitution.

The court held that there is no legal provision obliging anyone to sing the national anthem. “Proper respect is shown to the National Anthem by standing up when the National Anthem is sung,” the court said. “It will not be right to say that disrespect is shown by not joining in the singing.”

The court emphasised the importance of religious freedom, observing, “Article 25 is an article of faith in the Constitution, incorporated in recognition of the principle that the real test of a true democracy is the ability of even an insignificant minority to find its identity under the country’s Constitution.”

In the conclusion to its judgment, the bench of Justices O Chinnappa Reddy and M M Dutt remarked: “Our tradition teaches tolerance; our philosophy preaches tolerance; our constitution practices tolerance; let us not dilute it.”

THE GOVERNMENT IS WEIGHING A STANDALONE LAW TO REGULATE AI

AI law may cover agent autonomy, deepfakes

Two legal experts have been asked to submit separate draft liability frameworks for AI models

Soumyarendra Barik
New Delhi, July 21

THE MINISTRY of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY) is exploring a consent-based framework for synthetically-generated content, along with curbs on agentic AI autonomy, and regulatory sandboxes for high-risk applications as it weighs a separate law to regulate artificial intelligence (AI), *The Indian Express* has learnt.

Synthetically-generated content is digital media made or altered by AI, rather than humans. The AI law is likely to be presented as a standalone piece of legislation, rather than being under the umbrella of the Information Technology Act, 2000, a senior government official told *The Indian Express*.

The cyber laws division of the IT Ministry, which is responsible for formulating laws and policies that impact tech companies, has been asked to carry out a regulatory analysis of the IT Act, and the various rules made under it, to understand existing gaps.

In the case of agentic AI, the government is expected to consider how much autonomy such agents should have, and whether they should be permitted to retain and reuse data.

Agentic AI refers to autonomous AI systems that go beyond simply generating text. Given a high-level goal, they independently plan multi-step actions, utilise external tools, and adjust their strategy in real

• REGULATING AI

IN THE case of agentic AI, the government is expected to consider how much autonomy such agents should have, and whether they should be permitted to retain and reuse data

AGENTIC AI defers to autonomous AI systems that go beyond simply generating text. Given a high-level goal, they independently plan multi-step actions, utilise external tools, and adjust their strategy in real time to achieve the desired outcome with minimal human supervision



THE IT Ministry is also expected to consult the RBI, and the SEBI, to set up a regulatory sandbox for AI applications, particularly in high-impact areas such as finance and public services

time to achieve the desired outcome with minimal human supervision.

The IT Ministry is also expected to consult the Reserve Bank of India (RBI), and the Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI), to set up a regulatory sandbox for AI applications, particularly in high-impact areas such as finance and public services.

Platform liability, safe harbour in AI era

Another major conversation currently taking place is the liability that AI platforms and companies – that have developed them – should have for the content that the models generate.

In the consumer Internet world, social media platforms have something called safe harbour, which is legal immunity from hosting user-generated content. This is based on the idea that platforms can not preempt what a user is going to post, and therefore should not be held liable for any problematic speech they may have made.

In the AI world, however,

that same logic is difficult to translate directly. AI models are trained on content present on the Internet, and inevitably use that information to build their responses.

However, while pattern matching for keywords, these models also editorialise their responses in a way where it may be hard to track its exact statements back to a particular source.

It is understood that the government has asked two legal experts from the private sector to submit separate draft liability frameworks for AI models.

Queries sent to the IT Ministry remained unanswered until publication.

“Building a consent-based framework for synthetically generated media would be one of the key requirements for an AI law. We have seen the rapid proliferation of deepfakes on the Internet, and most of them, if not all, are generated by using pictures or videos of individuals whose consent has not been sought by the creator or the platform generating such media,” a senior government official said, requesting anonymity.

“Though the Digital Personal Data Protection Act, 2023 looks at broader privacy issues, the questions of consent and data ownership in an AI age merits further examination,” he added.

India’s data protection law exempts personal data that has been voluntarily made public by an individual from any protections that the Act offers.

Many believe that if an AI platform were to scrape pictures of a person’s public social media profile, for instance, such processing is unlikely to have any guardrails under the data protection law.

While the government is now working on an AI law, it had previously said that the country does not need one, and its existing laws were enough to deal with challenges posed by the proliferation of AI platforms.

The government has been enacting piecemeal legislation to bring AI under control. For example, in April, it proposed that social media companies like YouTube, Instagram and X will have to “continuously” display labels on content generated through AI.

However, a broad rethink from targeted lawmaking to an expansive regulatory framework comes amid growing instances of objectionable, high-quality deepfakes, and the government’s anxieties over agentic AI.

Earlier this year, it reprimanded Elon Musk’s Grok AI for aiding in the creation of objectionable deepfakes of women.

In a meeting with stakeholders last month, the IT Ministry particularly flagged Singapore’s governance framework for agentic AI (which was announced in May), and how some jurisdictions that have generally followed a lighter-touch approach to regulation were also re-examining their position.

RBI plans wider test for foreign control of firms

Mumbai: The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) on Tuesday proposed changes to foreign exchange management rules, broadening the conditions used to determine whether an Indian firm is controlled by foreign shareholders.

The changes were part of draft rules that the RBI said aim to create a more user-friendly framework for foreign investment. The central bank has sought feedback by 31 August.

Under the proposed framework, an Indian entity would be deemed foreign-controlled if a foreign investor holds 10% or more of voting rights, can appoint a majority of directors or can influence management and policy decisions.

The proposals drew immediate concern from lawyers, who warned the new numerical threshold could expand the definition of foreign control.

“The RBI has introduced a numerical benchmark that does not presently exist and could expand the circumstances in which a foreign investor is regarded as exercising control and attract higher compliances,” said Anuroop Omkar, founding partner at AK & Partners, a law firm.

The RBI proposals are part of India’s broader push to attract foreign investment including through tax cuts and lower compliance costs, even as capital outflows persist.

The concern centres on minority investors. Anjali Malhotra, partner, regulatory, at consultancy firm Nangia Global, said the proposed definition of control warrants further consideration. **REUTERS**